

tend to see the Autumn nature of these Banal actions as a grim inevitability to be called upon only in the direst circumstances.

Of course, a changeling isn't locked into one frame of mind once she enters it, nor must she progress strictly from childling to wilder to grump. A sudden spark of inspiration or infusion of Glamour can move a grump to a wilder or even a childling again, reopening their eyes to awe and wonder. Similarly, a childling particularly devoted to a certain task or dream may shut out other influences and become a grump for a time, dedicated to one purpose at the expense of other, more extravagant experiences. While a changeling's adjusted attitude is not uncommon, it is always something of note, especially if the shift brings more Glamour into the world. Progressing forward is seen as the natural order of things taking effect, but a wilder or grump moving backward is a rare and celebrated experience.

Childling

It is a brave and rare soul that can fend off the forces of Banality as effectively as a childling. These precious changelings still know wonder and awe. The world around them is a magical playground full of adventure and mystery. With their fantastic dreams and boundless imaginations, childlings are virtual magnets for Glamour, and as such are fiercely protected by other changelings in their community.

Typically, the first seeming of a changeling's life after she emerges from her Chrysalis is the childling. A childling is in awe of the magical world around her. The Dreaming is closest to these changelings, and the influx of Glamour that carries them into their new world keeps Banality at bay. Fairy tales they have heard all their lives are suddenly coming true, and they star in their own story, sometimes discovering that the people around them are also characters. A childling might find that the teacher who encouraged her artistic talents or the eccentric aunt that always told the most magical stories are privy to her new world as well, there to lend a sympathetic ear and a helping hand to the transition. These older changelings are invaluable to blossoming childlings, the rare forces in the world to embrace the magic that is so apparent instead of stamping it out in favor of logic and reason.

In such a mundane world, a childling's claims of having a tiny dragon for a pet, or fairy friends that sing her to sleep every night, are often dismissed. As she grows older, those around her often discourage these claims and insist that such things aren't real. The most mundane authorities in her life may even begin to punish her for these wild notions; in such a Banal atmosphere, most changelings eventually run away, fleeing their homes or schools and hopefully finding a freehold to take them in. This early introduction to Banality is all most childlings need to decide to never grow up, lest they lose the magic in their lives.

However, if a changeling truly does refuse to face maturing, she faces other risks. The naïve mindset that protects her from Banality can also begin to set her apart from the mortal world, preventing her from relating to her mortal friends and family as they leave behind the things of their childhood. Of course, the changeling herself may consider "settling down" and "growing up" the harbingers of Banality, and may very well begin to resist

even more. Luckily, in this day and age, with adolescence prolonged and the need to "grow up" put off for a time, it is easier than ever for a changeling to remain safely adrift in the sea of late bloomers before her attitude is truly considered problematic. With their unique points of view, some changelings can even manage to live their entire lives as childlings. To the mortal world, these folk are the eccentric innovators, able to conceive of and create things no one had dared to dream of yet, but are usually a bit... off, by mortal standards.

This desperate aversion to moving on does have its own consequences. Childlings are the most likely of all changelings to succumb to Bedlam (p. 294). Too much time spent in the Dreaming and surrounded by Glamour is just as bad as too little, and a changeling that finds herself meeting this fate lets her mortal self slip away entirely in favor of her fae half. With the inevitable march of time staring them down, few wish to hasten the process of becoming Undone.

Balancing Banality and Bedlam is not the only problem childlings face. Even one that has moved past mortal childhood might not be taken seriously, due to her flighty nature and idyllic outlook. While she may have led countless previous lives and recall her past experiences as time moves on, she is still regarded as immature or unseasoned and can run into difficulty trying to gain respect or credibility. Commoners and nobles alike run into this problem, and even those that have moved back to this mindset find that their peers suddenly consider their ideas lofty and inconsequential, despite being tempered by years of experience and wisdom. Sometimes, this is for good reason. A childling's outlook may bring out the sudden desire to create something enormous and wonderful, without considering any possible consequences. Though the wisdom to temper the idea is sometimes there, the sheer excitement can sweep anyone off their feet quickly enough to disregard it. While these impulses aren't usually much of a problem, it's easy to forget that not every dream is a sweet one — nightmares can come to life, too. Every teddy bear protector is there to fight something, after all.

Courts: Childlings are perhaps the most fluid in their changing allegiance to courts. As the least likely to consider the consequences of their actions, the line between Seelie and Unseelie can be as thin as a prank gone too far or a "harmless" creation put into greater context. In certain contexts, the line is more distinct; a Seelie childling revels in the beauty of the world, and is easily excited by all the wonderful things around them. These things can be distracting at any age, especially for someone working in a dreary office or in a highly repetitive job. Seelie childlings will find as much magic as they can, even in these less-than-ideal circumstance, and strive to remain positive and help those around them.

Unseelie childlings, on the other hand, can be complete nightmares. With little care for consequences or thinking through the details, they don't consider the harm that will come to others, intentionally or unintentionally, in their pursuits. As Glamour is usually easy for childlings to come by, those that are Unseelie seek to obtain as much as they can. While they don't have an inherently negative outlook, they are more likely to put their personal interests over those of others.